He/She/It?

By Jan Baross

INTRODUCTION

HE: *(as if talking to a child) When a mommy and a daddy love each other VERY much.*
SHE: *(bluntly) But the mommy doesn't want to be a mommy.*
HE: *(earnestly) And the daddy desperately wants to be daddy*
SHE: *(sarcastically) The daddy goes off and finds a . . . replacement mommy.*
HE: *(sympathetically) But the daddy still loves the mommy very much.*
SHE: *(admitting) And the mommy still loves the daddy very much.*
HE: *(hopefully) So…*
SHE: *(smiling)They work things out.*
BOTH: *He/She/It? By Jan Baross*

(SHE enters nervously. HE sits reading. Both are intense and fighting to keep themselves and each other under control.)

SHE: Is she here yet?

HE: Calm down, will you?

SHE: This is calm. You know this is calm. You know this is what calm looks like when I do it. [hearing something off stage] That's her.

HE: That's a car.

SHE: So? She doesn't drive?

HE: She's coming by bus. She'll get off at the corner and …

SHE: Walk into our lives and surround us like a big blue mountain range.

HE: It'll just be a talk. A small talk.

SHE: A mountain range is coming for tea. How do you talk small to a mountain range?

HE: You promised to give it a chance.

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SHE: Alright! What do you want? You want ...

HE: Small talk. Nothing beyond a chat.

SHE: My stomach is clenched. I can't talk with a clenched stomach.

HE: Nothing has been decided. Nothing. It's really up to you.

SHE: Oh, suddenly it's up to me!

HE: Just say "no," and the whole thing is off.

SHE: Just say "no."

HE: "No." It's simple.

SHE: *(Quietly)* No.

HE: What?

SHE: I said, no!

HE: Don't panic!

SHE: *No!*

HE: What do you mean, when you say "no"?

SHE: You said I could say it and it would all be over.

HE: Is that what you're really saying?

SHE: How many ways are there to say it! No. No. *No!*

HE: You can't mean that. You haven't even met her.

SHE: It's not *no* to her. It's *no* to you. This is all about you.

HE: Is that what you think?

SHE: Do you know what happened the last time I said no to you?

HE: *(Pause)* Well, what?

SHE: I didn't see you for two years.

HE: A long weekend. Christ. Your memory.

SHE: Alright, a long weekend that lasted two years. Because I said no.

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HE: Because I want a child!

SHE: I don't.

HE: I know.

SHE: And if I say no to this new plan, you're gone again. With her.

HE: No. I promise to stay.

SHE: You'll resent me.

HE: I'll get over it.

SHE: Over what? What are we talking about?

HE: A baby. Mine.

SHE: So. Go marry her.

HE: She won't marry me.

SHE: You asked her to marry you?!

HE: No. She announced it when we met. She doesn't want to marry, period.

SHE: That's how she starts her conversations? Hello, I won't marry you.

HE: Pretty close.

SHE: She just wants your . . . ?

HE: My baby.

SHE: My husband's baby.

HE: Ah baby, you're my wife. I love you.

SHE: And her!

HE: In a way.

SHE: What way?

HE: She's motherly. No. Nurturing.

SHE: I'm not?

HE: You are, in your fashion.

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SHE: But she'd be a better mother for your child?

HE: Our child. All three of us.

SHE: We all call her Mom?

HE: We've talked about artificial insemination.

SHE: *We?* Who? Her?

HE: And me.

SHE: And where was I?

HE: On our minds every minute. We don't want to hurt you.

SHE: *(Beat)* Hold onto that thought.

HE: She has the baby. She lives next door. That's all.

SHE: Next door?

HE: That's why it's important that you like her.

SHE: I don't *want* to like her. I don't even like you at this moment!

HE: Do you want me to leave?

SHE: Did I say that? I said I don't like you at *this* moment. *This* moment is over. It is now *that* moment. I'll die if you leave me again.

HE: I was miserable without you.

SHE: What can we do?

HE: We'll visit with her and the baby several times a week. That's all it amounts to.

SHE: For God sakes!

HE: It won't take anything away from you.

SHE: Except you.

HE: You've got me. I'm not going anywhere.

SHE: Except next door.

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HE: *(Intensely)* I've got you and I'll never let you go.

SHE: You'll never let me go?

HE: I love you so much, it makes me tremble.

SHE: That's terror.

HE: I'm trying to be honest...

SHE: You've always been honest about what *you* want. I know exactly who you are, and it scares me.

HE: I've got room in my heart for more, that's all.

SHE: How much more? Are we going to adopt Czechoslovakia?

HE: Sweetheart.

SHE: I can't give you everything you want! I don't even want to.

HE: I know.

SHE: We'd be terrible parents.

HE: Absolutely!

SHE: We *need* parents.

HE: Absolutely.

SHE: *(Desperately)* Oh, Yes! Yes! I want to give you a baby! Is that what you want me to say?

HE: No. I don't want you to be the baby's mother.

SHE: *(Terribly hurt)* I'll be nurturing!

HE: Sacrificing won't work. You'd hate the pregnancy, your figure, the demands, time away from your career. And then you'd hate me.

SHE: Just like you'll hate me if I say no. What's she like?

HE: I told you.

SHE: Not like me.

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HE: She's not as attractive as you are. *(Beat)* She's kind.

SHE: Not like me.

HE: The world needs career people too.

SHE: She can't do what I do.

HE: That's right. Your work is very unique.

SHE: But you prefer that heifer!

HE: Where do you get off insulting a woman because she's nice?!

SHE: *(Overlap)* Mooooo!

HE: *(Overlap)* You're hopeless! Don't you malign kindness because you don't understand it. Not everyone's a paranoid like you!

SHE: You want to leave me! Admit it!

HE: She was right. She said you'd throw a fit! We knew you'd ...

SHE: *Oh,* excuse me for being paranoid!

HE: Stop it, Hon! Stop it! You're doing this crazy stuff to us again.

SHE: *What?*

HE: What do you really want? Bottom line.

SHE: You. All to myself. You. Not wanting a baby. You. Not hating me for saying no. You and me. That's all.

HE: That's all I want. You and me.

SHE: And baby makes three. And Mamma makes four.

HE: *Alright! Alright!* Maybe I can't have everything!

SHE: My God! Did you really say that?

HE: Forget everything I said.

SHE: What? You don't really mean it.

HE: Maybe it's a passing thing, you know, wanting to be a father.

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SHE: Now, hey.

HE: I lost my passion for sailing.

SHE: You got seasick.

HE: Maybe I can make myself seasick when I think of babies.

SHE: Is she the only solution?

HE: She's the only woman I ever met who wants my child and doesn't want to get married.

SHE: And you're the only man she knows who wants her to have his child and doesn't want to marry her.

HE: Right.

SHE: Thank God you found each other.

HE: Funny how things work out.

SHE: Listen! Is that the bus?

HE: Yes.

SHE: Well?

HE: Will you talk to her?

SHE: Did we ever dream we'd be this adult? *(Knocking)*

HE: She's knocking.

SHE: *(Angrily)* Why doesn't she use the doorbell?

HE: Broken.

SHE: *(Angrily)* You still haven't fixed it?

HE: Priorities.

SHE: It's been broken a long time!

HE: Yes, a very long time.

SHE: You should fix it!

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HE: *(Beat)* We both should fix it.

SHE: *(Beat)* You and me? *(Pause. Softens)* A project for two?

HE: Just for two.

SHE: *(Smiles)* We've always fixed it before.

HE: *(Laughs.)* We've got so much invested in the thing.

SHE: Will you really try?

HE: With all my heart.

SHE: *(Relief)* Thank God! I love you.

HE: I love you. *(Pause. Softly)* Darling.

SHE: Yes?

HE: Would you mind answering the door?

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jan Baross
Book: More One-Act Plays for Acting Students
ISBN: 1566080878
Publisher: Meriwether Publishing
Date (Month/Year): July 2003

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